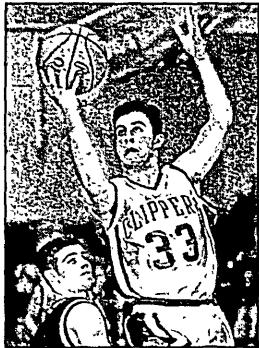


HIGH SCHOOL BASKETBALL

Fast Break

A quick look at action on the courts



MARVIN FONG / PLAIN DEALER

Clearview's Bret Schuster drives on Keystone's Todd Hodkey.

THE WEEK IN REVIEW MONDAY

Olmsted Falls' girls handed visiting Buckeye its first loss of the season, 51-47, in a nonleague game. Look for a possible rematch in the Division II district finals.

TUESDAY

The latest boys state rankings hadn't hit the streets when Midpark and St. Vincent-St. Mary suffered upset losses on the road. Midpark, ranked seventh in Division I, was overwhelmed by Medina, 85-32. SVSM, ranked third in Division III, was dumped by Western Reserve Academy, 60-51. Midpark coach Duane Sheldon said it wasn't time to hit the panic button, but admitted the Meteors had some work to do.

WEDNESDAY

Vermilion's girls lost, 69-53, to Garfield Heights in the first of two consecutive games where the Sailors will face one of the top players in Northeast Ohio. Allison Lipinski scored 27 points to lead Garfield Heights.

"Lipinski is probably the best guard we've seen in five years," Vermilion coach Skip Davis said. "And I really believe Garfield Heights [14-3] is the best team we'll face this year."

THURSDAY

Despite losing their emotional leader — senior Jacqui Lingler — to a knee injury, the Independence girls continue to find a way.

After victories over Brooklyn and Columbia, the Blue Devils stand alone in first place in the MAC-8 at 10-1, 11-2 overall. Independence took sole possession of first place after Brooklyn defeated Lutheran West, 36-31. Lutheran West entered the Brooklyn game ranked sixth in the Associated Press Division III state poll.

THE WEEK AHEAD TODAY

Can Rocky River get back into the Southwestern Conference race? That question will be answered tonight when the Pirates play host to conference leader Olmsted Falls. The varsity tipoff is scheduled for 7:30.

Rocky River, which defeated Olmsted Falls on the road last month, lost three of four SWC games before pulling itself together last weekend. Behind the play of senior forwards Jeff Peate and Mike Woodward and senior point guard John Caruso, the Pirates scored 91 points in an SWC victory over Bay on Jan. 22. Less than 24 hours later, they laid 105 points on previously undefeated Lutheran West in a nonleague headliner at Lutheran West. Peate scored a career-high 38 points at West, including nine 3-pointers.

Olmsted Falls, ranked 19th in The Plain Dealer poll, features veteran guard-forward Manzie Williams and senior sophomore Mike Gansey, a 6-5 forward. As usual, the Bulldogs have been getting tremendous fan support. In last month's game against Rocky River, several of the Bulldogs' faithful greeted the Pirates' bus with jeers as it attempted to pull into the parking lot. Last season, Olmsted Falls' student body was so vocal that it took away the home-court advantage at Rocky River.

TUESDAY

Though less than 10 miles apart, Villa Angela-St. Joseph and Eastlake North have never played a regular-season girls basketball game. That changes when VASJ (13-1) plays at North (10-3). There won't be a bigger girls game in Lake County this season. VASJ (13-1) is ranked No. 1 in the state Division III and Plain Dealer polls. North (10-3) is 10th in Division I and third in The Plain Dealer. The game pits two of the area's best post players — VASJ's Sarah Zdesar against Kaayla Chones — and two top guards — VASJ's Regina Smith against Erica Zielski.

Free Throws

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Teamwork lifts East Tech into Senate lead

By DICK ZUNT
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

East Tech sits alone atop the Senate Athletic League after methodically defeating host Glenville, 70-59, yesterday to break a first-place tie.

With one league game remaining, defending champion East Tech is 9-1 and assured of at least a tie for a repeat regular-season championship. Glenville and John Hay are tied for second at 8-2.

East Tech led from the tipoff to the final buzzer, with Glenville closing the gap several times. Each time, East Tech (10-3 overall) answered rallies by the Tar-

EAST TECH
GLENVILLE70
59

blooders (9-6).

Junior guard DeAndre Foster scored a season-high 20 points to lead the Golden Scarabs.

"Coach said to keep penetrating," Foster said. "This worked better in the second half."

"At first, I was penetrating by passing the ball and then I was penetrating by shooting, and this opened up the whole floor. We wanted to work as a team, and we came out hyped to play."

"I'd like to thank the team. It was not just me. There are no individuals, just a team."

Senior David Gaines, who

scored 15 points, nine in the fourth quarter, said: "We played one of our best games as a team. For my part of the game, I went all out in rebounding. I had some nice rebounds."

"My teammates worked the ball down to me in the post very well."

Sophomore Darren Robinson scored 14 points, all on field goals.

A layup by Robinson after the opening tip started the Golden Scarabs to a 14-8 lead at the end of the first quarter. They led, 29-21, at halftime.

East Tech, which worked the ball with precision, led, 45-34, after three quarters and increased the margin to 64-50 with 1:29 left.

Glenville sophomore Aaron Nichols, who tied junior teammate Antonio Johnson for team honors with 16 points, sank two 3-pointers, and 6-7 senior center Marcel Reynolds sank a 3-pointer in the last 1:20 to help the Tar-blooders close the deficit to 68-59 with 22 seconds remaining.

But East Tech's Foster closed the scoring with a layup with seven seconds remaining.

The Golden Scarabs came into the Glenville gym expecting a noisy crowd.

"I told the players to 'keep your poise during the noise,'" said East Tech coach Ray Durban.

"I'm really proud of the kids with the poise and control they showed," Durban said. "They

were focused and ready for a big game. We played in their house, and we knew that it would take a championship-level effort to beat them."

"Give a lot of credit to DeAndre [Foster] for playing his best game of the year. A key was keeping Glenville off the offensive boards. Our defense was outstanding."

Said Glenville coach James O'Neal Johnson: "I don't think that my guys were prepared mentally. They were physically, but not mentally. We missed a lot of layups."

"East Tech took us out of what we wanted to do. We were at home, but didn't do well at home. A slower game was to their advantage."

Defensive sting

Hornets' pressure sparks win

By EDDIE DWYER
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

It is no secret that John Hay's Tyrone McCann and Chester Mason "got game."

But they also have a sense of team play that has keyed the Hornets' drive to a spot in the city playoffs.

McCann and Mason, flashing their individual skills when necessary and getting their teammates involved at both ends of the court, led a 60-48 victory over Cleveland East yesterday in a Senate Athletic League boys basketball game at John Hay.

The Hornets, who finished with four players in double figures, improved to 9-4 and moved into a second-place tie in the Senate at 8-2. The top four teams advance to the playoffs. East, which is clinging to the fourth playoff spot, slipped to 8-5, 6-4.

JOHN HAY
CLEVELAND EAST60
48

"We had to bring up our intensity on defense a notch or two," said McCann, referring to the Hornets' effort in the fourth quarter, which saw them outscore East, 23-13. "If we continue to play as a team and play tough defense, we'll be just fine."

John Hay, which wraps up its Senate schedule at John F. Kennedy on Tuesday, found itself trailing, 22-13, after East sophomore guard Quenton Savage hit consecutive 3-pointers with 5:17 remaining in the first half.

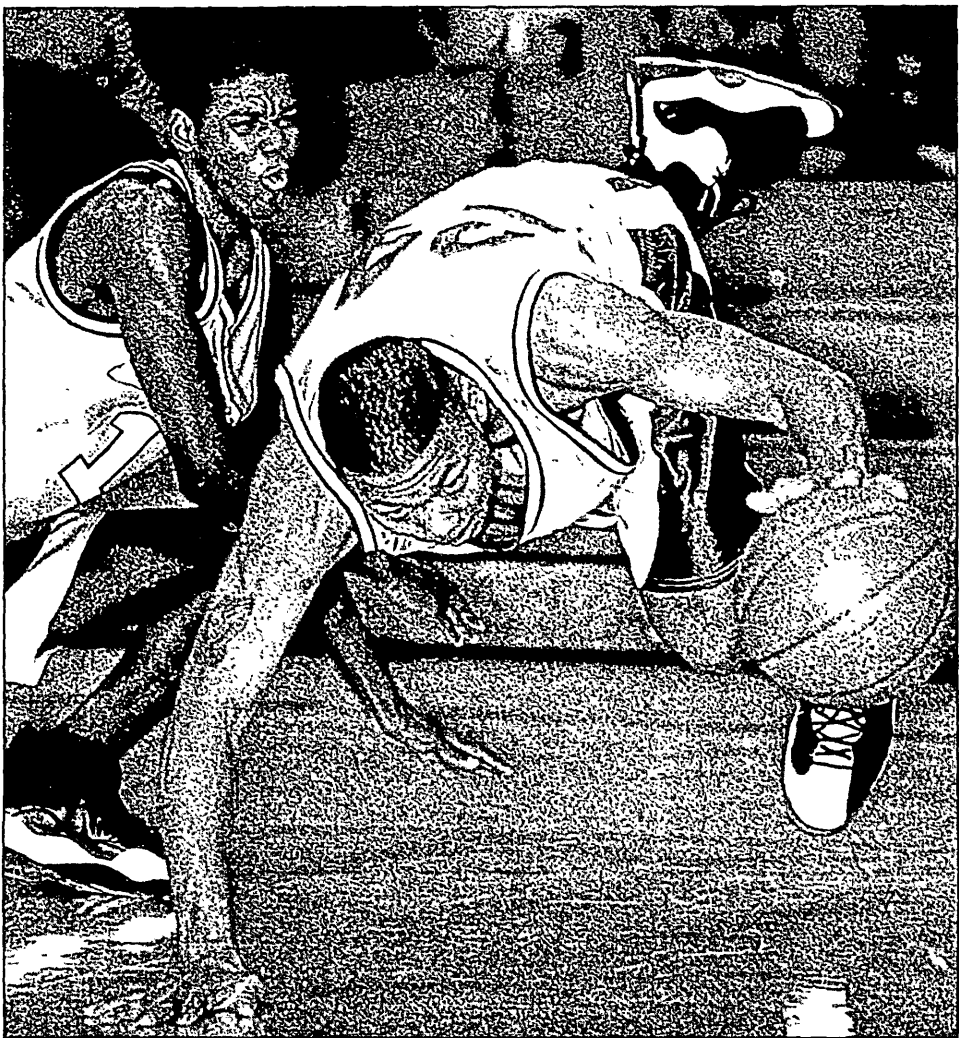
But Hay, switching to an aggressive man-to-man defense, went on a 9-0 run and tied the score at 22 with 2:22 left in the half.

Trailing, 24-22, at halftime, the Hornets continued to pressure the ball and deny the passing lanes. A putback by forward Jerome Turner and a steal and a slam dunk by Mason gave John Hay a 28-26 lead with less than two minutes gone in the third quarter.

"I'm fortunate in that I not only have good players, but quality individuals as well," said Hornets coach Tony Wilcox, a 1956 graduate of East Tech who began coaching in the city in 1964. "They make me look good."

After a 3-pointer by McCann extended the Hornets' lead to 33-28 with 4:19 left in the third quarter, East picked up its half-court offense.

Another 3-pointer by Savage



JOHN KUNTZ / PLAIN DEALER PHOTOGRAPHER

Tyrone McCann is fouled by Cleveland East's LeRon Robinson in the third quarter of John Hay's 60-48 victory yesterday.

'We had to bring up our intensity on defense a notch or two. If we continue to play as a team and play tough defense, we'll be just fine.'

TYRONE McCANN, John Hay guard

cut the deficit to 35-33, and after Mason and East's Antonio Montgomery exchanged layups, John Hay led, 37-35, entering the final eight minutes.

The Hornets, fronting East's bigger post players and doing a solid job of switching on defense, extended their lead to 42-35 on McCann's second 3-pointer and a spinning one-hander down the lane by guard Raymond Baker.

After a timeout by the Blue Bombers, Mason slammed home two points off an assist from

Baker, and John Hay led, 49-37, after McCann hit a driving one-hander high off the glass.

McCann, a senior who earned Plain Dealer Player of the Week for his efforts in Senate victories over East Tech and Lincoln-West, finished with a team-high 14 points. Mason, a junior, scored 13 points and had several key assists, and Baker and Turner had 11 and 10 points, respectively.

"We have a player in Tyrone who is averaging more than 20 points a game," Wilcox said with

a wide smile. "But he is willing to sacrifice his points for the team."

The Blue Bombers, who got a game-high 18 points from junior forward Richard Hampton and 16 points and four 3-pointers from Savage, closed to 51-41 on two free throws by Savage with 1:59 left.

But the Hornets, who finished 6-0 at home, responded with three free throws by forward Alvenil Alexander and settled the issue when Mason came up with another steal and drove nearly the length of the court for a crowd-pleasing reverse dunk.

"Richard [Hampton] and Quenton [Savage] did well for us," said East coach Dwight Hollins. "But, it's time for some other people to step up. We're young, and they have players like McCann and Mason. McCann played like a senior, hitting the crucial shots when they needed them."

Sims' jumper does the job for Buchtel

FROM STAFF REPORTS

When in doubt, call on your son. Especially if he is one of the more talented point guards in Northeast Ohio.

Buchtel coach Harvey Sims did just that last night as his son, Andre, prevented the Griffins from suffering their first loss in the Akron City Series.

The visiting Griffins, on the strength of a 10-foot jumper by Andre Sims with 10 seconds left, held off Akron Garfield, 70-68. Sims finished with a game-high 21 points.

Butchtel, ranked third in The Plain Dealer's Top 25 boys basketball poll, improved 12-1, 10-0 in the City Series. Garfield, which missed two shots in the final seconds, slipped to 5-8, 5-5.

St. Edward 64, Benedictine 56 — The Eagles are back.

St. Edward, behind 19 points by junior guard-forward Jeff Huber and 18 points by sophomore forward Jawad Williams, stunned 10th-ranked Benedictine in a non-league game in the Eagles' nest.

The Eagles, who graduated the nucleus of last season's Division I state championship and nationally ranked team, won for the fourth time in 12 games. Benedictine, Ohio's two-time defending Division II state champion, slipped to 7-6. The Bengals got a game-high 30 points from senior guard Chris Leanza.

Brecksville 59, Brunswick 54 — The Bees, behind 31 points by senior guard-forward Ryan Stefanski, improved to 12-2 and solidified their 13th-place ranking in The Plain Dealer's Top 25 poll.

Stefanski, a four-year starter and the most prolific scorer in Brecksville history with 1,545 points, entered the game averaging 24.2 points.

Rocky River 52, Fairview 30 — The Pirates, behind 19 points by senior forward Jeff Peate, improved to 9-4 and set the stage for tonight's Southwestern Conference headliner against conference leader Olmsted Falls at Rocky River.

Ranked 18th in The Plain

Dealer poll, the visiting Pirates held Fairview to 10 points in the first half.

Olmsted Falls 57, North Olmsted 54 — The Plain Dealer's 19th-ranked team survived

overtime behind a 4-for-4 effort from the free-throw line by Larry Mucha. The Bulldogs got a game-high 20 points from sophomore forward Mike Gansey in improving to 9-2.

Padua 73, Elyria Catholic 66 — John Link showed the way with 27 points as the Bruins prevailed in a North Coast League matchup in Elyria. Matt Wilhelm led the Panthers with 23 points.

Independence 69, Lutheran West 55 — Despite 35 points by senior forward Chris VanBuskirk, Lutheran West suffered its first loss in the MAC-8 and its second in 10 games.

Independence featured a balanced attack. The Blue Devils (6-7) got 17 points from forward Erik Siska and 16 points from forward Brian Burns.

Villa Angela-St. Joseph

88, Canton McKinley 80 — The Vikings' frontcourt of Scott Melle, Antoine Dunklin and Jerrod Calhoun accounted for 55 points, 20 by the 6-8 Melle.

VASJ (10-2), ranked fourth in The Plain Dealer poll, led, 45-34, at halftime and turned back a fourth-quarter rally.

Solon 87, Mayfield 61 — The seventh-ranked Comets (12-0) got 21 points from junior Eric Sanders in defeating the Wildcats for the second time in five days. Solon also prevailed in a makeup game at Mayfield on Monday night, 77-61.

Senior forward Drew Carter, an Ohio state football recruit as a wideout, contributed 14 points, and Mayfield got 19 points from junior forward Seid Tanovic.

Brooklyn 91, Gilmour 61 — The Hurricanes (10-1) tuned up for tonight's visit from Lutheran West by dominating the Lancers in MAC-8 action. Brooklyn, ranked 16th in The Plain Dealer poll, got a game-high 25 points from senior forward Jimmy Derzko.

SVSM holds off rally by Walsh

By TIM ROGERS
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

St. Vincent-St. Mary started fast and faded at the finish.

Walsh Jesuit got off to a slow start but finished with a flourish.

SVSM's start was better and lasted longer than Walsh Jesuit's finish, and it led to an 80-73 victory in a physical nonleague game in front of a packed house at SVSM.

Using the athleticism of Miquel Irvin, Maverick Carter and John King, the Irish stormed to a 20-point lead after three quarters before the Warriors rallied with a lopsided fourth quarter in which they outscored the Irish, 27-16.

ST. VINCENT-ST. MARY
WALSH JESUIT80
73

Walsh came close to making it a five-point game, but a 3-point shot by senior Tom Bird rimmed out with 24 seconds remaining, and King made two free throws with 22 seconds to go to put the Irish comfortably in front. It was their seventh victory in eight games heading into a date with Central-Hover tonight.

The Irish, ranked third in the state in Division III and coming off a stunning upset at the hands of Western Reserve Academy on Tuesday, saw their lead shrink mainly because they struggled at the free-throw line down the stretch. In the final 3:29, they missed 12 of 20 foul shots. For the game, they made 16 of 35 (46 percent). The Warriors made 21 of 29.

"We're usually a pretty good free-throw shooting team," said SVSM first-year coach Keith Damrot, whose team entered the game shooting 64 percent from the line. "We just had the wrong guys shooting at the wrong times."

Carter, a junior guard, led the Irish with 28 points, six rebounds, three assists and two steals. Irvin, who said he would sign a national letter of intent Wednesday to attend the University of Toledo on a football scholarship, had 18 points, 11 rebounds and two steals. King, who is getting into shape after missing the first four games with a sprained ankle, finished with 13 points and eight rebounds.

Senior forward Pat O'Brien led Walsh with 27 points and six rebounds. Senior guard Nick Catanzarite had 18 points, and junior Justin Alaburda scored 10 points.

"Their first 16 minutes were better than our last 16," said Walsh coach Frank Lupica, whose team slipped to 8-4. "We had no chance in the first half, and in the second half, we had a slim chance. But I am proud of the way our kids came back. A lot of teams would have folded being down by 20, but our kids showed me something in the second half."

Lupica expressed concern over the officiating. He said he wasn't upset, but he said he had some questions.

"At times, they should have thrown yellow flags instead of using their whistles," he said of the officials. "We are not a physical team, and when they let St. V get away with the hand-checking and holding, it makes it real difficult for us."

"The thing that puzzled me is that all three officials acknowledged they saw it, but they didn't call it. If they call hand-checking early on, the kids will back off. But if you don't call it, they will keep on doing it, and it turns into holding."

Carter said playing physical was part of the Irish game plan.

"We had to come out strong after the other night, and Walsh is a finesse team, a team that likes to play on the perimeter," Carter said. "Don't get me wrong, Walsh is a good team. But coach told us that we had to play them physical."